

Excel Charting Cheat Sheet

Use this page while completing Chapter 4: Creating Effective Charts in Excel.

Step	What to Do
1. Prepare the data	Keep data in a clean table with clear headers. Do not include blank rows inside the data range.
2. Select the range	Select both the labels and the values before inserting the chart.
3. Insert the chart	Use Insert > Recommended Charts, or select a specific chart type.
4. Add context	Add a useful title, axis labels, and a legend only when needed.
5. Clean the design	Remove clutter, avoid 3-D effects, use readable text, and choose colors with purpose.

Which Chart Should I Use?

Purpose	Recommended Chart	Example
Trend over time	Line chart	Sales over 12 months
Compare categories	Column or bar chart	Sales by region
Parts of a whole	Pie chart with 5-6 slices max	Department budget
Relationship between two numbers	Scatter chart	Ad spend vs. revenue

Helpful Shortcuts

Shortcut or Command	Use
Alt + F1	Create a chart instantly from selected data
Ctrl + Shift + Arrow keys	Select connected data quickly
Chart Design > Change Chart Type	Try a different chart type
Chart Design > Switch Row/Column	Change how Excel plots the selected data

Before You Submit a Chart

Ask: What question does this chart answer? Is the title clear? Are the labels readable? Did I remove anything that distracts from the message?